

The Way to *Nibbāna* (Part 1 of 2)

How to attain Nibbana as a Buddhist layman - Part 1

Late Ven. Waharaka Abhayarathanalankara Thero

The original document was drafted off of a video with English subtitles by Janith Boniface Fernando. A Word document was compiled using that English text by Lair Valio Alves and Seng Kiat Ng.

- The following document was prepared by Lal Pinnaduwwage by revising and expanding the above document.
- I am going to leave some time stamps so that one can see the relevant part of the video.
- This document covers only the first half of the video.

Question: What is the ideal way to achieve *Nibbāna* without delay, while attending to the day to day activities of lay life?

Since we have no idea as to when this human life will be over, we need to make progress on the Noble path in this life as quickly as possible. But we are lay people with other responsibilities too.

Venerable *Bhante*, will you be kind enough to tell us the way?

Waharaka Thero: That is right. One does not necessarily need to become a *bhikkhu* to attain *Nibbana*. First, we need to figure out the Path that anyone can follow.

Many lay persons have attained the *Sotapanna* stage while living their family life as husband and wife.

- Some have been living family lives and then have become Never Returners (*Anāgāmi*). and completed their *samsaric* journey subsequently.
- Some even become Arahants and completed their *samsaric* journey, while leading a lay life. Of course, at that point one will need to become a *bhikkhu*.

Whatever way we are going to take towards *Nibbana*, we should have a good idea of the path that we need to follow.

- If we plan to drive to a certain city, we need to figure out the directions first. We cannot just jump into the car and start driving.
- It is the same for attaining *Nibbana*.

Now if you look around, you can see different people practicing all sorts of things to get to *Nibbana*.

- Many *bhikkhus* today practice different methods. However, if we ask them whether they have truthfully attained a *magga phala* (one of the four stages of enlightenment) or a *jhana* (*Dhyana*), most of them just say they are still working on it.

There are a few individuals who claim to have achieved the *Arahantship*. However, if we question them, whether they are certain as to getting rid of their *raga* (attachment to sense pleasures), *dosa* (anger), and *moha* (delusion), we do not get a convincing

answer. If you observe their behavior, it is clear that they get angry even at the slightest provocation. Or they seem to have many worldly desires.

- Then there are some who have very nice, quiet manners, but do not seem to have grasped the essentials of Buddha Dhamma.
- Therefore, we cannot really conclude, just by looking from the outside, whether someone has actually achieved a *magga phala* or not.

To get to a *magga phala* one needs to have at least realized the dangers in the desire for sensual pleasures; greed is another name of that. Anger is another facet of greed. Furthermore, when the mind is covered with greed, we cannot learn Dhamma and get rid of *avijja* either.

- Thus, we need to figure out how to reduce greed.
- Both greed and anger arise due to ignorance or *avijja*. We could say that *avijja* is the ignorance of the teachings of the Buddha.
- Therefore, “seeing the dangers in sensual pleasures” is the first step.

In simpler terms, we have to figure out the way to keep us from giving in to desires or cravings. That is the first step.

- If we can figure out a way to lose cravings for sense pleasures, we will no longer be impassioned by worldly things and make wrong decisions.

When one realizes the dangers in craving for worldly things, one starts losing such cravings. We can say that one becomes **dispassionate** about worldly pleasures through that deeper understanding.

However, the **dispassion** comes by understanding the real nature of this world, **not just by observing a set of precepts** promising to abstain from immoral acts.

Commitment to abstain from immoral acts alone will not lose one’s cravings for sense pleasures.

- One needs to realize that such sense pleasures do not provide a long-lasting fulfilment.
- Not only that, but craving for sense pleasures can lead to much suffering in the future. We need to “see” that danger.

Some of the people who had encounters with the Buddha were very aggressive people, and even killers.

- When Buddha visited his residence, *Alawaka yakkha* threatened to rip open his heart, grab him from his feet and fling him over to the other side of the river. It was not the case that *Alawaka yakkha* came to the Buddha and respectfully asked for advice.
- Angulimāla drew his sword and chased the Buddha with a necklace of human fingers hanging around his neck.
- But after hearing a few Dhamma verses, they understood the basic principles of Dhamma. Only then, they became restrained.

Hence, it is quite clear that *Alawaka yakkha* or Angulimala did not follow precepts or rituals.

- They just understood some critical basic facts.
- From that fundamental understanding emerged a kind of discipline to the mind, speech and body.

If we are abstaining from something with sheer will power, that can fail. That failure happens especially when temptations become high.

- **Instead, moral discipline (*sīla*) has to arise out of an understanding of the nature of this world.**
- That is called morality that comes out of understanding. That *sīla* is “unperturbable” and is called “*saṃvaraṭṭhena sīlaṃ*” or *sīla* that comes from reducing/removing “*saṃ*” from one’s mind.
- Nowadays, many people think that reciting the five (or eight) precepts and try to abide by them is considered *sīla* or morality. Without a true understanding of the underlying principles, such “forced morality” cannot be sustained.

First, let us try to understand WHY we tend to do immoral deeds, and WHY it is so hard to stop doing them.

- If we engage in killing animals for sport, that is based on a perceived pleasure. Of course, eating the animal’s flesh is another form of “pleasure.”
- If someone steals or engages in sexual misconduct, there is a reason for it. There must be some type of a “payback” that one is expecting. Always, it is a sense pleasure.

But if we realize that such actions will have dangerous and unseen consequences, would we still do them?

Consider the following analogy. Someone gives us a very expensive and tasty chocolate bar. We would be happy to eat it. But if we are told that it is poisoned and will kill us in a month, would we still eat it? Of course not.

- The Buddha explained that there are “hidden dangers” in sensual pleasures. Those dangers are not direct like the poison in chocolate bar in the above analogy.
- The dangers arise in a complex way. That is why it is hard to understand.

If we realize that there are truly no lasting “pleasures” in certain activities, and instead they can lead to much suffering, would we still willingly engage in them?

To explain those “hidden dangers,” the Buddha introduced three words with eight letters. “*Attakkarā thīnapadā Sambuddhena pakāsithā, na hī sīla vatan hotu uppajjāti Tathāgatā.*”

- That means “a Buddha (*Tathāgata*) is born NOT just to show how to live a moral life, but to reveal three words with eight letters to the world.”
- Those three words are *anicca, dukkha, anatta*.

A Buddha arises in this world to explain those three words, and not to advise to live by a “moral code” or a set of precepts. What is essential is to understand the meanings of these three words. Without that understanding rules or precepts will not work.

When we understand the meanings of those three words, we will realize that there is no value in sensory pleasures. Instead, there can be hidden dangers in our quest to seek sensory pleasures.

- That goes against what we humans are accustomed to. It is ingrained in our minds the “value” of sensory pleasures.
- Our minds are not capable of ‘seeing’ the wider world with 31 realms, and that life in some of those realms can be very harsh.

(6.40) When we start understanding this “previously unheard Dhamma or the teachings” of the Buddha, the value that we place on worldly pleasures for worldly things will start to reduce.

- We will realize that we had placed high value on things that are really worthless.

With that new-found understanding, a *Sotapanna* would have given up an innumerable wrong deeds. Such “giving ups” happen voluntarily, without an effort, after “seeing” the “worthlessness of worldly pleasures” and their dangerous consequences.

On the other hand, for an **inept worldly person (*puthujjana*)**, it is very stressful to try to give up “worldly pleasures.” For them, worldly things are of utmost importance.

Therefore, the difference between a *Sotapanna* and a *puthujjana* is the “state of mind.” A *puthujjana* sees a high value in many worldly things and thinks that they provide long-lasting happiness.

07:21 Someday, when a *puthujjana* understands Buddha Dhamma, he will come to realize that all this while he has given such immense importance to some petty worthless things.

- Then he would realize how foolish it was to work so hard to get hold of “valuable things.” In some cases, one would have hurt others during such activities. All in vain!
- Then he would lose the desire for many of those “valuables”, especially if such efforts involve hurting others, i.e., if such efforts involve immoral deeds.
- That sense of worthlessness of worldly things registers in the mind when one comprehends the *anicca* nature.

08:00 The Buddha said that the amount of defilements that still remains intact in the case of a *Sotapanna* is analogous to the amount of water that remains on a finger-tip, after you have dipped your finger in a mighty ocean. The water in the ocean is comparable to the defilements in a *puthujjana*.

- That difference comes from the change of mindset. Not by following a set of precepts.

In another analogy, compare the grains of sand on a finger nail to the amount of sand on Earth. That is the difference between the defilements left in a *Sotapanna* versus in a *puthujjana*. A *puthujjana* would have defilements comparable to all the sand on Earth to get rid of. A *Sotapanna* has left only a small amount left to get rid of.

08:23 How do we even start to explain such a HUGE change in a person? How can a *Sotapanna* get rid of such a huge amount of defilements, just by comprehending the true nature (*anicca* nature) of this world?

The change from a *puthujjana* to a *Sotapanna* is astronomical.

This is almost inconceivable to some of us, the idea that the stream enterers (*Sotapannas*) with such a small amount of defilements left. Especially when they live family lives, raising children, and seemingly enjoying “sensual pleasures.”

But they have abandoned a huge part of “attachment to this world and even to *kama loka*”. That is why they will NEVER engage in immoral actions to gain sense pleasures. Even though they still have a perception (*sanna*) for enjoying sense pleasures, it is INGRAINED in their minds that all such “pleasures” are fleeting and “empty of any value.”

There is a Tipitaka story about a woman born into wealth. She attained the *Sotapanna* stage at an early age. But she eloped with Kukkuta Mitta, a poor man who killed forest animals to make a living. She went to the forest with him and raised seven children, while helping her husband with his livelihood.

- It is hard for us to figure how she could have removed a huge fraction of defilements from her mind and still seemed to have lived a “not so moral life.”
 - The following description was inserted by Seng Kiat, which describes her story in the *Tipitaka*.
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NO EVIL BEFALLS THOSE WHO HAVE NO BAD INTENTION

Kukkuṭamittanesādavatthu

*Pāṇimhi ce vaṇo nāssa,
hareyya pāṇinā viṣaṃ;
Nābbaṇaṃ viṣamanveti,
natthi pāpaṃ akubbato.*
Dhammapada 124

Kukkuta Mitta the hunter and his family comprehend the Dhamma

At Rajagaha there was once a rich young girl who had comprehended the Dhamma. A hunter by the name of Kukkuta Mitta came into town in a cart to sell venison. Seeing him, the young lady fell in love with him immediately. She followed him, married him and lived with him in a small village. As a result of that marriage, seven children were born to them and in the course of time, all of them got married. One day, the Buddha surveyed the world early in the morning and found that the hunter, his children and their wives were due to realise the Dhamma. So, the Buddha went to the place where the hunter had set his trap in the forest. He put his footprint close to the trap and seated himself under the shade of a bush, not far from the trap.

When the hunter came, he saw no animal in the trap but a footprint and surmised that someone must have come before him and let out the animal. So, when he saw the Buddha under the shade of the bush, he took him for the man who had freed the animal from his trap and flew into a rage. He took out his bow and arrow to shoot at the Buddha, but as he drew his bow, he became immobilised and remained fixed in that position like a statue. His children followed and found their father. They also saw the Buddha at some distance and thought he must be their father's enemy. All of them took out their bows and arrows to shoot at the Buddha, but they also became immobilised and remained fixed in their respective postures. When the hunter and his

children failed to return, the hunter's wife followed them into the forest, with her in-laws. Seeing her husband and her children with their arrows aimed at the Buddha, she raised both her hands and shouted, 'Don't kill my father.'

When her husband heard her words, he thought, 'This must be my father-in-law', and her children thought, 'This must be our grandfather', and thoughts of loving-kindness appeared in their minds. Then the lady said to them, 'Put away your bows and arrows and pay respect to my father.' The Buddha knew that, by this time, the minds of the hunter and his children had softened and so he willed that they should be able to move and put away their bows and arrows. After putting away their bows and arrows, they paid their respects to the Buddha. He expounded the Dhamma to them. In the end, all of them understood the Dhamma.

The Buddha returned to the monastery and told the other bhikkhus about the hunter and his family. They then asked the Buddha, 'Venerable Sir, is the wife of the hunter who has comprehended the Dhamma also not guilty of taking life, if she had been getting things like nets, bows and arrows for her husband when he went out hunting?' The Buddha replied, 'Bhikkhus, those who are *sotāpannas* don't kill, they don't wish others to get killed. The wife of the hunter was only obeying her husband in getting things for him. It never occurred to her to think she was helping her husband to commit evil deeds. Just as the hand that has no wound is not affected by poison, so since she has no intention to commit evil she has not created any bad *kamma*.'

We need to think about that account to figure out how such a person, seemingly living an "immoral life" could have gotten rid of huge amount of defilements from her mind.

The key point is that what she removed from her mind is what is hidden in a mind. **A huge amount of defilements is hidden in any person. That is called *anusaya*.**

It is not possible to figure out how much any normal person is "attached to this world." It is like an iceberg. **One can only see the tip of tip of an iceberg. A vast amount of ice is hidden in the water.**

- That is why we cannot just look at the demeanor of a person and decide whether that person is an immoral person or one with *magga phala*.

She had only a tiny amount of "ice left" but it was very visible. **On the other hand, an average human would show up even less but could have an enormous amount of "ice (defilements)" buried under water, hidden.**

It is only when "triggered" by a strong enough temptation that such hidden *anusaya* come to surface. **An average human has an enormous amount of "hidden *anusaya*."**

- Most of it may never "come to the surface" even once in a given lifetime. But it is there.

In contrast, that woman had an inconceivable amount of *anusaya* already removed from her mind.

For instance, we have heard many people say that they do not desire much of anything. But unless that person had attained a *magga phala*, he/she would have an enormous amount of desires. **They may not be aware of that.** Such *anusaya* can popup to the surface only when “conditions are right.”

- One may genuinely believe that one has no aspirations or expectations. But it is just that it is all hidden.

10:13 *Asava* means our expectations. They remain hidden as *anusaya* and come to the surface (based on strong *arammana*) as *asava*.

- These aspirations or expectations are driven by ignorance and greed. They perpetuate the rebirth process (*saṃsāric* journey.)

When these expectations disappear through UNDERSTANDING of the nature of this world, all such hidden *anusaya* will just evaporate.

- **That can happen in just a single thought-moment.** For that to happen, must first cultivate the path for a while and “prepare” the suitable mindset. It normally happens while listening to a discourse by a Noble Person (*Ariya*.)
- That is like the rising Sun evaporating a dense thick mist and making everything perfectly clear. The darkness of ignorance evaporating in an instant. But that may not be “felt” at the moment.
- That is the moment of attaining the *Sotapanna* stage.

That purified mind will never engage in immoral deeds suitable to bring rebirth in the *apayas*. That person, over time, will realize that he/she has indeed gotten rid of a huge burden. “*Chanda raga*” for worldly things has been significantly reduced.

- But the desire for sense pleasures is likely to stay on at a reduced level. Even though the wrong views and the corresponding *ditthi vipallasa* have been REMOVED, *sanna vipallasa* and *citta vipallasa* may remain.
- **But that remaining *vipallasa* are a tiny fraction compared to *ditthi vipallasa* that one had removed.** See the recent post on “[Difference Between ‘Me and Mine’ and ‘Sakkaya Ditthi’.](#)”

10:59 One who stays in the rebirth process expects “worldly pleasures” with “*chanda raga*”. The word “*raga*” means to “roam around” implying “roaming in the *saṃsāric* journey.”

The desire to attain *Nibbana* is also a *chanda* or a desire. It is *chanda iddhipāda*,

One needs to clearly see the difference between those two desires or expectations.

- One has *chanda raga* when one desires worldly things that may provide sensory pleasures. That desire comes from attaching to worldly things (*tanha*) due to *avijja*, not knowing the unfruitfulness and hidden dangers in them.
- One would desire *Nibbana* when one can “see” with wisdom the dangers of having worldly desires. That means comprehending the *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* nature of the world.

The desire for *Nibbāna* (*chanda iddhipāda*) is a part of the 37 Factors of Enlightenment (*Sattatīṃsa Bodhipakkhiya dhammā*).

- *Chanda iddhipāda* is also part of the four bases spiritual power (*cattāro iddhipāda*).

The worldly pleasures are sought with ignorance and greed.

When we say “liking for worldly things” what are those things that belong to the world?

- The world includes eyes, ears, tongue, nose, body, and the mind. With those we experience things in the world: people and things, sounds, tastes, smells, touches, and concepts.
- Since we desire to experience them, we keep making them again and again in the rebirth process.
- **Yes. It is the *javana* power in our THOUGHTS that create *kammic* energies to give rise to “mental-bodies” (e.g., *gandhabbas*) for future lives.**

For example, the *gandhabba* for a human life is created with such *kammic* energy. That *gandhabba* has the seat of the mind (*hadaya vatthu*) and a set of five *pasada rupa* that **detect or FEEL the sense inputs**.

- Our physical eyes, ears, etc are just “devices” that bring in those external sensory inputs (with the help of the brain.)
- It is the same process that leads to the arising of a hell being, a Deva, or an animal.

Why do we need those five physical senses and the mind? We need those to see objects, to hear sounds, to smell odours, to taste foods, to feel touch, and then to think of all of them again and again (and to enjoy such thoughts.)

These things that we enjoy with our six senses are out there in the external world. We WANT TO find out what *rupa* are out there, what kind of pleasing sounds, what type of tasty foods, etc. Even long after such sensory experiences, we re-create them in our minds and try to enjoy those memories too.

That desire to “know and find out” about all those things that are “out there” is in inherent NEED that we all have. Even when it is not necessary to know some of these things, whether it is really necessary or not, there is a curiosity to KNOW.

12:17 This is the reason for the existence in the world. As long as we want to experience those external sensory inputs, our minds WILL make the conditions to make that happen. It may not happen the way we want. Because arising of future lives is based on natural laws and those are laws of *kamma*.

That is the critical point to understand. One’s desire is just to enjoy some worldly pleasures. But what one does to get such pleasures, one may do immoral deeds and such deeds will have their consequences.

- In the case of a rape, the desire is bodily pleasure. But since that involved hurting another person, that “violent mindset” generates an energy which gets deposited in the *kamma bhava*.
- At the *cuti-patisandhi* moment of grasping a new *bhava*, that *kammic* energy can come back to the mind and lead to an existence corresponding to such a violent mindset. That is a *niraya* or a hell.

- What we receive is not the OUTCOME we hope for. What we get would be according to CAUSES created in the mind. For example, no one wants to be born an animal. But if one commits rape that mindset goes with that of an animal. Therefore, an animal birth would be the outcome.
- However, if that person had attained a *magga phala* in the meantime (after committing a bad deed), then that purified mind cannot grasp such a violent mindset. That is why a person with *magga phala* will not be reborn in an *apaya*, even if he/she had committed such a violent crime.

We tend to get involved in worldly affairs regardless of even when there is no clear benefit.

- If one hears a sound, he would look towards that direction. Why? We want to know what made that sound, what it is about.
- If it's of interest (even if it has not benefit to us), we may get further involved.

Our need to know and inquire about many things in the world has no bounds. Many people spend a lot of time trying to find out about how humans evolved, or whether the universe is finite. Quite possibly one can spend a lifetime pursuing such issues, but what would he/she have gained by the time death comes?

- Of course, it would not matter if there is not rebirth.
- But if rebirth is valid (whether one believes in it or not), then one would have just wasted valuable time that could have spent on learning Dhamma and making progress on stopping the suffering-filled rebirth process.

There are no limits to what we want to find out.

- When one “sees” the true nature of this world, one will understand that it is a waste of time to engage in such efforts.
- Rather an effort should be made to understand the nature of the “hidden part of this world” that only a Buddha can discover. That reveals the existence of many other realms where there is unimaginable suffering. Those things one would NEVER be able to figure out. Only the mind of a Buddha can ‘see’ the wider world.

For example, some people spend time researching the lives of famous or wealthy people. Then they keep thinking and desiring to become one of such famous or wealthy people.

- If they instead spent time learning Buddha Dhamma, they would realize that no matter how famous or wealthy one becomes, that would have to be given up in a ten twenty, or fifty years. What is the use of that?
- Again, if one does not believe in rebirth, that waste of time may not matter.

15:01 The desire to “investigate” the appealing and interesting aspects of the external world will go away completely only at the Arahant stage.

- Until then one will gradually give up more and more such “investigations” of unfruitful things.
- First one will give up the desire to “gain happiness” by engaging in immoral activities. Those are the activities related to the five precepts.
- But instead of forcefully giving them up, one will ‘see’ the futility and the dangers in such activities. That comes from understanding concepts like *kamma/kamma vipaka*, the rebirth process within 31 realms, etc.

The more “expectations” that one has about this world, the more one is bound to this world. One would have unimaginably large “expectations” if one has not “seen” the *anicca* nature.

- A person would say, ‘I don’t have such expectations’. But since it is hidden as “*anusaya*” as we discussed above, one would not know how strongly one is “bound to this world.”

When one starts seeing the “unfrutfulness” and “dangers” in this world (i.e., the *anicca* nature), one will start losing huge chunks of such expectations even without realizing it.

- That is one easy way to understand this point, without quoting Pali verses. Anyone can get an idea that way.
- Of course, that has been explained in the *Tipitaka* in many different ways.

Therefore, when one attains the *Sotapanna* stage, one would have realized that there is nothing much to really wish for in this world. He/she would not wish for “pleasing things” with a high-level of desire. Of course, the tendency to enjoy sense pleasures is likely to be there. But since its strength has been reduced, the “*javana* power” behind any such desire will not be enough to induce highly-immoral deeds.

- Thus, no matter how strongly tempting, one’s mind would not ALLOW such deeds. One would not need to think about it or try to wilfully enforce it. It is automatic.

16:13 A *Sotapanna* may enjoy many sense pleasures as before. But deep inside would know that those are of fleeting nature, would not last long.

- The value of any sensory pleasure has been permanently downgraded in the mind.

This is the idea of losing defilements with “seeing Dhamma with insight” (*Dassanena Pahātabbā*).

- As we discussed above, an unimaginably large chunk of hidden defilements or *anusaya* would have been permanently removed.

Any visual, sound, taste, smell, touch would only provide a brief moment of pleasure **while the sensation lasts**. In most cases, we re-live such experiences and mostly enjoy “mind-made pleasures”. Those are “*samphassa-jā-vedana*” that we have discussed in several posts at the website.

- Therefore, the wrong view that such “pleasurable experiences” can provide long-lasting happiness will be gone for a *Sotapanna*.

17:19 Once getting to that stage, any left-over defilements are to be removed by meditation (*Bhāvanāya pahātabbā*.)

- That means one should keep contemplating the *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* nature.

Therefore, it is essential to “see Dhamma with insight” (*Dassanena Pahātabbā*) first.

- If one has not clearly ‘seen’ the true nature, there is no point in doing much of “formal meditation.”
- In order to be able to do “insight meditation” one would have to have grasped the *anicca* nature through reading and listening.

A person has to “visualize Dhamma,” and abandon a huge amount of *anusaya* (hidden defilements) first, as discussed earlier. Then that person (a *Sotapanna*) will be able to engage in insight Meditation and to get rid of the remaining defilements (***Bhāvanāya pahātabbā.***)

- Therefore, much that is abandoned by “vision” or “seeing with wisdom”, by reading and listening to Dhamma and contemplating (which could be called part of *bhavana*)

The point is that one needs to first read/hear those new concepts taught by the Buddha before one can even start contemplating on them.

- This is why it is said that one cannot attain the *Sotapanna* stage by just meditating.
- **First, one needs to learn the “previously unheard Dhamma” from a Buddha or a true disciple of the Buddha.**

That is why the four conditions necessary to attain the *Sotapanna* stage are: association with a Noble Friend (***Sappurisa saṃsevana***), hear correct Dhamma from that person (***saddhamma savana***), clearly see how life originates via *Paṭicca Samuppada* (***yoniso manasikāra***), and follow the path according to that understanding (***dhammānudhamma paṭipada***).

Another way to state:

- Association with “*sappurisa* (*sath + purisa* or “Noble friend”, i.e., an *Ariya*)”, sometimes called a “*Kalyana Mitta*.”
- Listening to Dhamma discourses (while reading is enough to get to *Sotāpanna Anugami* stage, listening is necessary to attain the *Sotāpanna* stage).
- Act with *yoniso manasikāra* (basic idea of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* and *Paṭicca samuppāda*).
- *Dhammanudhamma paṭipadā* (following the Noble Path in accordance with that new “vision”, which is beyond the mundane path)

In this process, one would understand how the world arises for oneself based on one’s cravings for things in this world. One would realize that there is nothing in this world that is worth craving for.

- That requires a good understanding of how life arises in different realms according to the *Paṭicca Samuppada* process.
- Furthermore, any and all realms have the *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* nature.
- One had previously pursued worldly things only because one did not know the “true nature.”

18:29 That means comprehension of the true nature of this world (*yathabhuta nana.*)

- With that understanding a huge amount of future expectations (*anusaya*) will be removed, as we discussed above.

However, he has not gotten rid of the aspirations to enjoy sensual desires. That still remains.

- He still wants to engage in fulfilling the five sensual desires.

- Attachment to sensory objects (*kāma rāga*) still there. Anger or frustration with others (*paṭigha*) is still there. Wherever there is desire (attachment), friction with those who oppose that (*paṭigha*) will be there.

One needs to cultivate the four parts of *Satipatthana* (*Cattāro Satipaṭṭhāna*) in order to get rid of *kama raga* and *patigha*.

- This is the ***Bhāvanāya Pahātabbā*** part that comes after attaining the ***Sotapanna*** stage.
- Therefore, one needs to read and listen to Dhamma AND contemplate on what is learned first. That is ***Dassanena Pahātabbā*** that comes first.

In other words, one needs to get to the *Sotapanna* stage (at least the *Sotapanna Anugami* stage with some understanding on *Tilakkhana/Paticca Samuppada*) before starting on *Satipatthana bhavana*.

- As we discussed above, a huge amount of hidden defilements would have to be abandoned by “seeing through wisdom” first.
- In other words, before proceeding on the Noble Path, one needs to figure out the Path. That is done with ***Dassanena Pahātabbā***.

What sort of Dhamma would bring about that new vision?

What we loosely termed in English as 84,000 teachings of Dhamma, are different paths to arrive at this point.

- That is because each person is different. But that does not mean one needs to learn about 84,000 ways of getting to the *Sotapanna* stage. In most cases, there are only subtle differences among those.

This is why it is good to explore different aspects of Dhamma until one finds a “latching point” to “engage”.

- For example, some people can better understand the five aggregate approach than the *Paticca Samuppada* approach at the beginning.
- By the way, that is why there are so many sections/subsections at puredhamma.net. **There is not need to understand them all. One needs to focus on a section or sections that one is able to understand.**

However, when one proceeds on ANY possible path, **they will ALL converge at the end to the Noble Path**. At that point, one will be able to see the “connections” among those various approaches.

That is why *Satipatthana* is sometime called the “unified way to *Nibbana*.” That will enable a *Sotapanna* to get rid of the remaining defilements of ***abhijja domanassa (kama raga and patigha)***.

This is why the verse, “*satimā vineyya lōke abhijjhā dōmanassam*” appear all throughout the *Satipatthana Sutta* which describes how to cultivate *Satipatthana bhavana*.

The Unified Path to eradicate *kama raga*, *patigha*, and *avijja* is the same as the Noble Eightfold Path.

20:02 An average human (or *puthujjana*) would have various forms of wrong views. To get to the Noble Path, all those need to be discarded via ***Dassanena Pahātabbā***.

- It is said that those ignorant humans who have not heard Buddha Dhamma may have various combinations of 84,000 distinct views. Those are various minor forms of 62 wrong views discussed in the *Brahmajala Sutta*.

The Buddha was able to recognize wrong views of each individual. Thus, he first pointed out the problems with those specific wrong views.

- Then the person would realize that he had wrong views about this world. In most cases, it is not knowing the unfruitfulness and dangers of attaching to worldly things.
- After realizing the problem of valuing and craving for worldly things, it would be easier for that person to see the correct path forward.
- That is where he would see the unified and only path, the Noble Path. That can be cultivated with *Satipatthana*.

That turning point is reached when one gets rid of the ten types of *miccha ditthi* and hears the true Dhamma. Now he would be able to comprehend the true nature of the world or *anicca, dukkha, anatta*.

- That true nature described by the three words with eight letters (in Pali) can be discovered only by a Buddha.
- That is why only a Buddha or a true disciple of the Buddha can explain the true meanings of those three words.

Now that one has gotten rid of the BASIC wrong views such as not believing in rebirth, not believing in *kamma/kamma vipaka*, the existence of the *gandhabba* (mental body), etc, one has the capability to the “big picture.”

- That big picture is the existence of 31 realms and a rebirth process that has no traceable beginning.
- None of those 31 realms offer refuge from suffering.
- Furthermore, our tendency to do immoral things to satisfy our senses WILL get us into trouble and thus we have spent most of our deep past in the four lower realms.
- When one starts seeing this “big picture” one would want to get out of this rebirth process as quickly as possible.

The first step is to see the *anicca* nature, that it would not be possible to attain a permanent happiness in the rebirth process. That any existence cannot be maintained to our satisfaction. Each and every existence WILL end up in getting old and death. No exceptions.

That *anicca* nature also prevails within a lifetime, from the moment one is born. One will be subjected to unexpected sufferings (injuries, sicknesses, etc).

- The *anicca* nature pervades every corner of every existence.

That *anicca* nature leads to suffering. That is expressed by the verse “*yad aniccam tam dukkham*”

- That suffering makes one without refuge in most cases (when one is born in an *apaya*), and that is expressed by “*tam dukkham tad anatta*” or “since it ends up in suffering one becomes helpless at the end.”

That is really the essence of Buddha Dhamma.

In the time of the Buddha, people did not have the opportunity to listen to discourse as frequently as today. Of course, writing was not widespread, it was not available in the written form.

- But many people grasped the essence of *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta* with a single discourse by the Buddha.
- Many who had never heard Buddha Dhamma sat down to listen to a discourse by the Buddha and got up having realized a stage of *magga pahala*.

Those people had no idea what Buddha Dhamma was about. But they were able to understand the futility of attaching to worldly things within a discourse that possibly lasted an hour or two.

Of course, they had been possibly exposed to *Vedic* teachings about *kamma*/ *kamma vipaka* and rebirth (more likely reincarnation that involved a “soul-type” concept). That probably helped them grasp things a bit faster.

- As explained in some posts at puredhamma.net site, teachings of Buddha Kassapa had come down many generations as *Vedic* teachings. While the concepts of *kamma* and rebirth were there, the true meanings had been lost.

The problem today is that the necessary steps to get to the Noble Path are covered. For example, many people spend years and years practicing breath meditation instead of trying to grasp the essentials discussed above.

- Many people who spend many days at a meditation retreat never learn the basic, essential concepts.
- Many of them have spent years learning and practicing breath meditation, but do not even believe in rebirth.

That is a very sad state of affairs.

The key to attaining Nibbana is to comprehend *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anatta*.

- However, one MUST get rid of the ten wrong views first.

22.30 Without moral conduct, one cannot get into a state of *samadhi* (not necessarily *jhana*). Without *samadhi*, wisdom cannot arise in a mind.

However, one should not assume that moral conduct means just obeying five or eight precepts.

- Moral conduct comes from understanding that immoral deeds have bad consequences. Such bad consequences include getting bad rebirths in the *apayas* (four lowest realms).

Another word for *dasa akusala* is *panca nivarana* (five hindrances). Those five hindrances cover the mind. It is easy to do *dasa akusala* when one’s mind is covered by those five hindrances.

The five hindrances are: Sensory desire (*kāmacchanda*), ill-will (*vyāpāda*), sloth-and-torpor (*tīna-middha*), restlessness-and-worry (*uddhacca-kukkucca*), doubt (*vicikicchā*).

- If one or more these are present, it is possible to commit one or more of those ten unwholesome deeds.

One does an *akusala* with a motive to destroy life, or to take what is not given, or to engage in wrong actions to get sensual pleasures, or to speak falsely, slanderously, harshly or idly. All such actions arise with greed (*abhiṇṇa*), anger/hatred (*vyapada*), and ignorance (*avijjā*).

- Therefore, the seven immoral deeds by actions and speech done with the three possible immoral states of the mind.

If any of those intentions arise in a mind that mind is covered with the five hindrances.

- A good example is when one becomes angry, At that time, the mind is covered with *vyapada*. That mind is unable see right from wrong.
- One can hurt or even kill others depending on the level of *vyapada* that arises.

If a mind is covered with five hindrances, that is not the time to read or listen to Dhamma. One needs to have a calm mind devoid of the five hindrances. For example, if one feels sleepy (*tīna middha*) or distracted (*uddacca kukkucca*) or confused (*vicikicca*) that is not a good time to learn Dhamma.

- This is why it may be beneficial to ‘set the background’ first, at least for some people.
- When I was small, I went with my family to the temple to listen to discourses. Before sitting down to listen, we would offer flowers to the Buddha, light some oil lamps, recite the customary verses, etc. The temple atmosphere itself had a calming effect.

It is not possible to understand Dhamma without getting rid of any bad intentions in the mind. And they can arise only if one or more of the five hindrances are present.

If one sits down with the intention of learning Dhamma, one would be unlikely to have any of those problems. That motivation itself can set the necessary background for some.

Samatha means to “come to equilibrium” or to “*sama*.”

- If there is greed or anger obviously the mind is far from the “equilibrium state”.
- An equilibrium state is free from anxiety. There is nothing much to do to “maintain it.”
- Think about the following analogy. If one is in warm room, that ambient temperature is away from the equilibrium, the temperature of the body. One can bring it to equilibrium by turning on a fan or an air-conditioner. If the room is cold, again it is away from equilibrium and one had turn on heat to get it to equilibrium.
- However, if the room temperature is close to the body temperature, one feels comfortable. One is relaxed. The body is in equilibrium.

A mind that is devoid of *akusala cetana* or five hindrances is a mind in equilibrium. It feels calm and is ready to learn new concepts. That is *samatha*.

- Now we can see why *sīla* comes before *samadhi* or *samatha*.

- One who has moral conduct does not engage in *dasa akusala*. That mind is devoid of five hindrances.
- Then if one is exposed to the correct Dhamma, one would be able to comprehend it and cultivate panna or wisdom.

That is *sila, samadhi, panna*.

24.30 That may not necessarily mean that one has REMOVED the five hindrances. They are at least suppressed at that time. That is called *Tadanga pahana*. It is a temporary *samatha* state or *Tadanga Samatha* state. But that is enough for the mind to grasp key concepts and to cultivate *panna*.

But that state of *Samatha* is not necessarily a *jhana*.

- A *jhana* is a deeper state of *samadhi*. It is called *Vikkhambhana Samatha* state reached via *Vikkhambhana pahana*.
- When the five hindrances are permanently removed, one gets to the *Sotapanna* stage. That is *Uccheda pahana*.

However, one can do *vipassana* or “gain insight” during *samatha*. That is enough to get one to *magga phala*.

Vipassana (or *vidassana*) means to “see in a special way”.

- Normally one sees the world as fruitful.
- With that “special seeing” one will realize that the worldly things devoid of any essence. That attachment to them will only lead to future suffering.